

Checklist:

Engineering Management Approaches

1. Work the policy, not the exceptions

- ☐ Define the goal the policy is meant to serve.
- ☐ Identify constraints that actually limit behavior.
- ☐ Avoid writing policies that do not constrain choices.
- ☐ Treat exception requests as signals, not one-off problems.
- ☐ Batch exception requests rather than handling each one immediately.
- ☐ Periodically refresh the policy based on collected exceptions.
- ☐ Avoid changing policy so often that policy becomes indistinguishable from exceptions.

2. Say no effectively

- ☐ Explain your team's constraints clearly.
- ☐ Separate velocity problems from prioritization problems.
- ☐ Use a delivery process view, such as a kanban board, to show where work gets stuck.
- ☐ Translate vague problems like "technical debt" into concrete, measurable examples.
- ☐ Identify whether the real constraint is capacity, prioritization, or relationships.
- ☐ When prioritizing, document incoming asks.
- ☐ Define guiding principles for selecting work.
- ☐ Test priorities with stakeholders.

3. Build your management philosophy

- ☐ Treat management as an ethical profession.
- ☐ Consider the impact of decisions on people, not just business outcomes.
- ☐ Build strong relationships before trying to solve hard problems.

- ☐ Prefer people over process when process is failing.
- ☐ Do the hard thing now rather than postponing it.
- ☐ Make decisions in this order: company, team, yourself.
- ☐ Think independently instead of blindly copying inherited practices.
- ☐ Revisit and evolve your philosophy over time.

4. Manage in and outside the growth plates

- ☐ Identify whether you are operating in a growth area or a stable area.
- ☐ In growth areas, prioritize execution over endless ideation.
- ☐ Reduce the backlog of obvious ideas before adding more.
- ☐ Accept that some work will be mediocre when constraints are severe.
- ☐ Outside growth areas, focus on fundamentals and steady improvement.
- ☐ Build relationships, develop your team, and prepare for future change.
- ☐ Match your leadership style to the current context.

5. Avoid common ways managers get stuck

- ☐ Do not only manage down.
- ☐ Do not only manage up.
- ☐ Manage your relationship with your management chain.
- ☐ Avoid optimizing locally at the expense of the company.
- ☐ Do not assume hiring solves every problem.
- ☐ Spend deliberate time building relationships.
- ☐ Define your role broadly enough to fill gaps.
- ☐ Give your manager room to make mistakes.
- ☐ Pause before “fixing” everything when joining a new company.
- ☐ Delegate rather than disappearing from the work.
- ☐ Stay connected to ground truth.
- ☐ Do not confuse team size, title, or authority with real impact.
- ☐ Trust the team enough to delegate.
- ☐ Let others manage their own time.
- ☐ Celebrate what is working, not only what is broken.

6. Partner with your manager

- ☐ Tell your manager what problems you are solving.
- ☐ Share how you are solving them.
- ☐ Communicate progress and where you are stuck.

- ☐ Explain what you prefer to work on and what you can staff.
- ☐ Share your workload and capacity.
- ☐ Discuss your professional goals and areas for growth.
- ☐ Clarify how you believe you are being measured.
- ☐ Learn your manager's priorities and pressures.
- ☐ Ask how stressed or busy they are.
- ☐ Look for ways to help them.
- ☐ Understand what their manager expects from them.
- ☐ Periodically write a self-reflection or career narrative and share it.

7. Find managerial scope

- ☐ Do not equate career growth only with managing more people.
- ☐ Identify key gaps in the organization.
- ☐ Take responsibility for increasingly complex work.
- ☐ Pursue hard, cross-cutting problems.
- ☐ Measure scope by impact and responsibility, not title.
- ☐ Build reusable systems that empower others.
- ☐ Stop using team size as the gateway to career growth.

8. Set organizational direction

- ☐ Recognize when feedback becomes scarce or vague.
- ☐ Accept that senior roles require setting direction with limited input.
- ☐ Mine broadly for ideas across teams, peers, companies, and papers.
- ☐ Separate idea discovery from judgment.
- ☐ Turn a large pile of ideas into a strategy.
- ☐ Identify the key pivots or tradeoffs in the strategy.
- ☐ Write down decisions clearly.
- ☐ Test the strategy with others.
- ☐ Refine confusing parts into smaller, clearer questions.
- ☐ Distill the final direction into a few memorable points.

9. Close out, solve, or delegate

For every recurring or unresolved problem, choose one:

- ☐ **Close out:** Make a clear decision and communicate it to resolve the specific issue.

- ☐ **Solve:** Design a system, norm, or process so this kind of issue does not recur soon.
- ☐ **Delegate:** Redirect the work to someone better positioned or responsible for it.
- ☐ Do not keep solving every problem yourself.
- ☐ Use this method for a week and review whether it improves your effectiveness.